# Competitor Research Report: Payment Verification App

Research report for the selected project idea: an app that helps businesses verify whether customer payments are real, pending, failed, or unknown.

| COMPETITORS REVIEWED | EVIDENCE USED | MAIN OPPORTUNITY |
|---|---|---|
| **2 apps** | **3 screenshots** | **Simple, trusted onboarding** |

## 1. Project Context

The selected project idea is a payment verification app for businesses. The app will help sellers, staff, and service providers confirm whether a customer payment has really gone through. This is important because many businesses currently face fake payment screenshots, manual checking, delays during sales, and confusion when customers claim they have paid.

The first version of the app can stay simple. A staff member should be able to enter or scan a transaction reference, customer phone number, or receipt ID. The system should then return a clear status such as successful, pending, failed, or unknown.

## 2. Competitor Research Summary

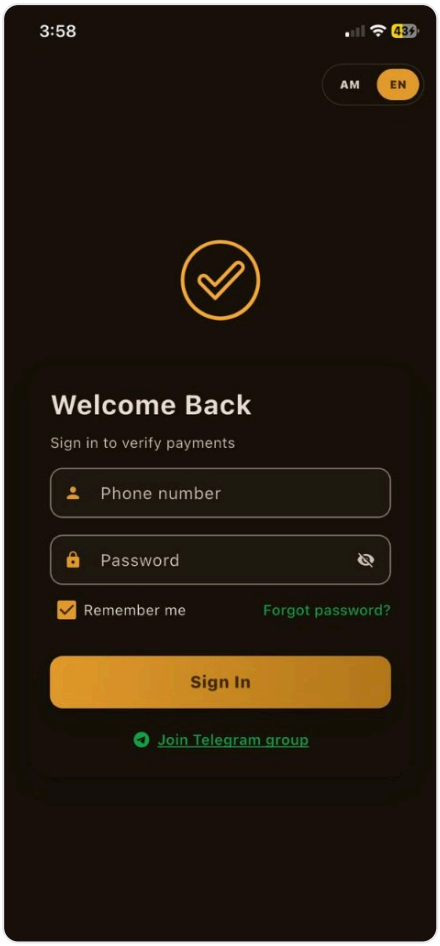
During competitor research, two similar apps were reviewed. The screenshots show that the market already has products trying to solve payment verification, which is a good sign because it proves there is real demand. However, both competitors also show serious weaknesses in onboarding, login, pricing, and dashboard usability.

The biggest issue observed is that the apps are not easy to start using quickly. For a payment verification product, this is a major problem because users need trust immediately. If registration, login, or payment setup is confusing, many small business owners may stop before they even understand the value of the app.

**Executive finding:** the weakness is not the payment verification idea itself. The weakness is the experience around the product: confusing registration, fragile login, high upfront payment, and dashboards that are not friendly for everyday business owners.

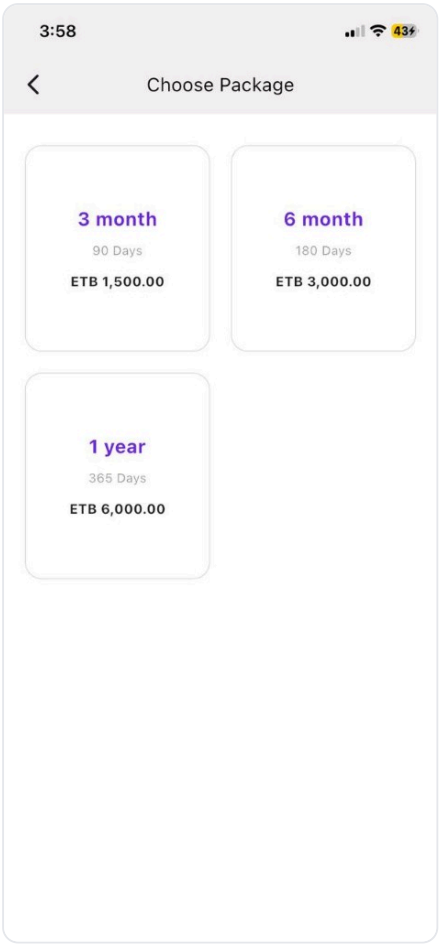
## 3. Evidence From Competitor Screenshots

## Screenshot 1: Login-first experience



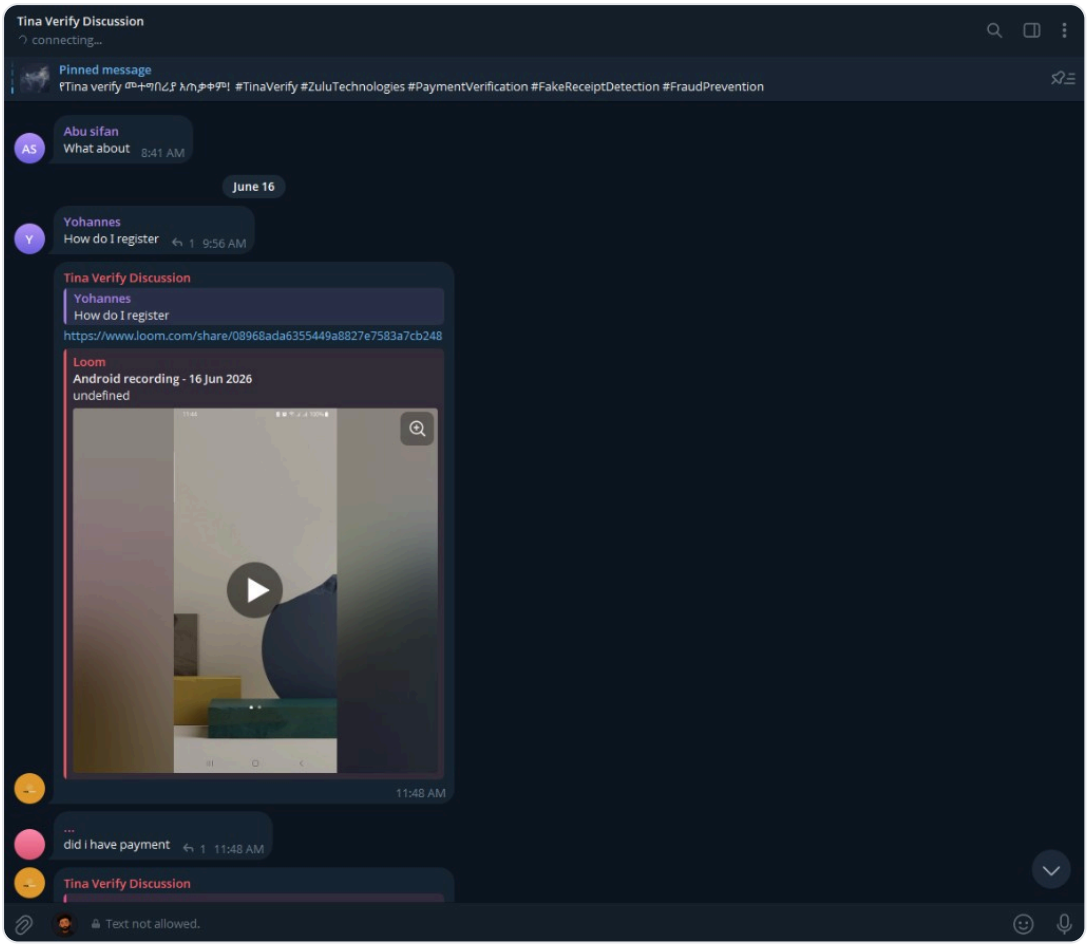

The first competitor app shows a login screen with phone number and password fields, but there is no clear sign-up option. This makes the first-time user experience confusing. A new user should not have to search through a group chat or follow complicated steps just to create an account.

## Screenshot 2: Package selection and pricing




The package screen shows that the lowest visible plan starts at ETB 1,500 for 3 months. This is a high starting cost for users who have not yet tested whether the app works for their business.

### Screenshot 3: User confusion in public group




The public Telegram group shows users asking basic questions such as how to register. This is important evidence because it shows that the onboarding problem is not only a personal observation. Real users are also confused.

## 4. Good Parts Observed From Competitors

The competitors confirm that payment verification is a real problem in the market. Businesses are already looking for tools that help them detect fake receipts, confirm transactions, and reduce manual checking.

Another good sign is that competitors are charging for access. This shows that the market may be willing to pay if the product saves time, prevents fraud, and gives business owners confidence during sales.

The competitors also show that a mobile-first approach is important. Since many Ethiopian businesses use phones for communication, sales, and payment confirmation, our app should be easy to use on mobile from the beginning.

## 5. Bad Parts Observed From Competitors

- **Complicated onboarding:** one competitor does not show a clear sign-up page, and users appear to need external instructions to register.
- **Poor authentication:** the second competitor app appears to allow registration with any phone number without proper verification.
- **Weak recovery:** if the password is forgotten, there is no reliable recovery path, which can lock users out of their accounts.
- **Poor session handling:** the login process feels like banking apps where the user has to log in again every time.
- **High upfront pricing:** ETB 1,500 for 3 months is a large barrier before users know whether the app works for them.
- **Dashboard complexity:** the dashboard appears cramped and difficult for non-technical shop owners and staff to understand.

## 6. Competitor Gaps And Our Response

| Area | Observed competitor issue | What we should include |
|---|---|---|
| Onboarding | Registration is hard to find or confusing; one app appears to have no direct sign-up page. | Make account creation obvious, guided, and fast from the first screen. |
| Authentication | Weak phone-number registration and broken recovery create trust problems. | Use phone verification, secure password reset, and persistent sessions. |
| Pricing | Entry plan starts at ETB 1,500 for 3 months before users know whether the app works for them. | Offer free scans and flexible weekly, monthly, and yearly plans based on scan volume. |
| Usability | Dashboards feel cramped and difficult for non-technical business owners to interpret. | Prioritize simple verification status, bank-level summaries, recent scans, and clear next actions. |
| Market focus | Competitors appear to be larger software vendors selling multiple products without deep focus on this workflow. | Win by focusing on one payment verification product and selling it with hands-on customer support. |

## 7. What We Should Include In Our App

**Simple sign-up:** the first screen should clearly support both sign in and create account. The flow should be easy: choose language, enter phone number, verify the number, create password, and start scanning.

**Secure account access:** phone number verification, password reset, and persistent sessions should be included from the beginning. A business owner should not need to log in again every time they open the app unless there is a clear security reason.

**Clear dashboard:** the first dashboard should focus on scan or enter payment reference, show verification status, show recent scans, and show simple summaries by bank or payment provider.

**Usage-based pricing:** instead of charging only for unlimited access, the plans should be based on scan limits. A suggested starting model is free access with 20 scans per month, then weekly, monthly, and yearly paid plans with higher scan limits.

## 8. Market Opportunity

The biggest gap is that the competitors seem to be larger software companies that build many products and then put them in the market for collection. They may not be focused deeply on this one problem.

Our advantage can be focus. We can build one strong payment verification product and sell it at the same time through direct customer education, onboarding help, and fast improvement based on user feedback.

This gives us a strong chance to compete. If we make the app simple, trustworthy, affordable, and focused, small businesses may prefer our product even if competitors entered the market earlier.

## 9. Conclusion

The competitor research shows that payment verification is a valuable project idea, but current solutions have important weaknesses. The most serious problems are difficult registration, weak login and recovery, high upfront pricing, and dashboards that are hard to understand.

Our app should solve these problems directly. The product should help users start quickly, test the value with free scans, understand payment status clearly, and choose a plan based on actual usage. By focusing on simplicity, trust, and customer support, we can build a better payment verification app for local businesses.